13:1
IndiGo's pilot-to-aircraft ratio, among the leanest globally

4,063
No. of flights cancelled by the airline in December first week

NOT PLAYING BY THE RULES

Much of the problem began with the introduction of a technical rule few passengers had heard of till now—Flight Duty Time Limitations (FDTL). These determine how long pilots can work, how much rest they must get, and how many night landings they can perform. They act as the invisible scaffolding of airline safety, designed to manage fatigue and improve safety norms. For years, Indian pilot unions and safety advocates had argued that the country's rules were outdated and that fatigue regulations were inseparable from a pilot's right to life, even dragging airlines and the DGCA to courts over this. After prolonged consultations and court interventions, the DGCA finally rewrote the norms under the Civil Aviation Requirements Section 7, Series J, Part III (Rev. 2). Under the new FDTL rules, weekly rest periods for pilots increased from 36 hours to 48 consecutive hours. Night-time flying rules were tightened with the definition of night duty being extended from midnight to 6 am rather than 5 am. The number of permitted night landings per pilot were cut drastically from six a week to just two. Also, no pilot could be rostered for more than two consecutive nights under the night duty period. Airline operators were expected to file quarterly fatigue reports of pilots.

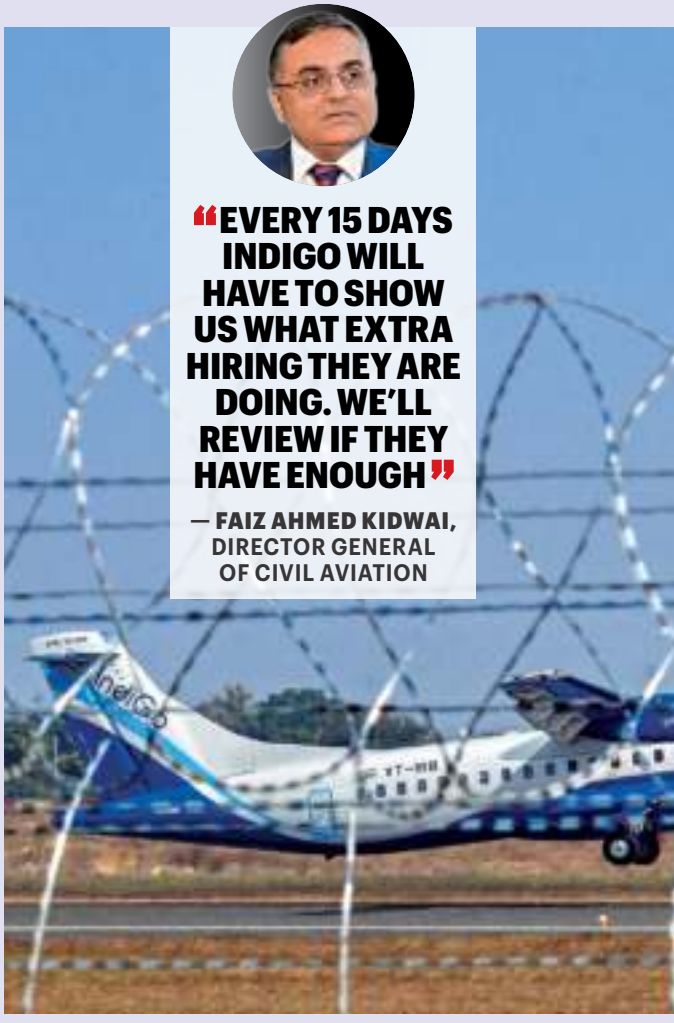
Drawing on fatigue science, India's aviation regulator evolved a new FDTL regime with 22 clauses. These marked a significant tightening not only when seen against India's own older rules. They either match or indeed have done better than the norms of the Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) in the US and the European Union Aviation Safety Agency (EASA)—capping night landings at two weekly (FAA-3, EASA-2), limiting weekly duty to 60 hours (FAA-60, EASA-60), and mandating 48-hour weekly rest (FAA-30, EASA-36). This new regime, which was apt to make safety experts happy but not airlines, was rolled out in two phases this year. On July 1, 15 of the simpler clauses came into force. For pilots, that brought a reduction in maximum daily flying time from nine hours to eight hours and capped the number of daily landings for them. Phase 2 kicked in on November 1, when the remaining seven rules were implemented, including stricter limits on night duties and an increase in mandatory weekly rest timings.

FLYING ON A RAZOR'S EDGE

Irked though they might have been, it was not as though the new FDTL rules came as a bolt from the blue for Indian carriers. The revised norms had been notified in January 2024, giving airlines nearly two years to prepare. With pilots now meant to fly fewer hours each month, airlines needed to hire more of them to operate the same number of flights.

For IndiGo, which prided itself on working with razor-thin buffers and yet extracting the maximum in terms of the hours it kept its aircraft in the air, the FDTL brought in major complications. Its entire economics was built on scale, with even a marginal reduction in pilot productivity requiring substantial hiring. Other carriers adjusted. IndiGo, critics argue, did not. Captain G.R. Gopinath, founder of Air Deccan and the man who rewrote India's aviation playbook two decades ago, does not mince words. IndiGo, he says, failed to recruit pilots in time and induct them early enough. His explanation is one word long: arrogance. "They believed they were so big, so influential, that if they delayed or showed reluctance, the DGCA would blink," he told INDIA TODAY. "They thought the rules would not really apply to them."

What unfolded in the weeks before November suggests something more calculated than oversight. As Phase 2 approached, the DGCA began asking airlines for preparedness reports. At the same time, carriers were required to submit their winter plans, detailing how they would manage operations during the fog-prone months when disruptions in northern India ripple across the network. Records reviewed by INDIA TODAY show that at least four meetings



"EVERY 15 DAYS INDIGO WILL HAVE TO SHOW US WHAT EXTRA HIRING THEY ARE DOING. WE'LL REVIEW IF THEY HAVE ENOUGH"

— FAIZ AHMED KIDWAI, DIRECTOR GENERAL OF CIVIL AVIATION

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